DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Why Does Evil Need Judgment and Consequences?

Daat Tevunot §118-120

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §118-120
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 30 March 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

A chef in reverse

The class continued near the end of §118 (page 272). A participant offered an analogy for what we had learned: a chef in reverse. There is emanation and there is concealment, mixed together; Hashem then separates the ingredients and chooses which combination goes into animals, into man, into each situation. The Rabbi agreed: "Excellent."

From imperfect to bad

Since HaKadosh Barukh Hu has both attributes, emanation and concealment, the result is soul and body, with the body lower than the soul and lacking things the soul does not lack. That alone does not make it bad. Imperfect is not bad.

But that would not have been enough for God's plan, which was always that man should have a propensity towards evil. So He made a greater concealment, and the result is real loss, real evil, and the ability to corrupt. Throughout history there have been great people who did great things for the world, and corrupt people who did terrible things. The Ramhal says God turns to evil, as it were, unwillingly, "with a heavy heart, so to speak".

Why must there be consequences?

Once there is the ability to do bad, there must be judgment and justice. The Rabbi went back to Derech Hashem: the best would have been perfect beings simply basking in goodness, but then we would not earn it. So there is a body, the body is not only imperfect but coarse, and we can corrupt.

He then asked: if I choose good, I gain closeness. If I choose not to, and even abuse my powers, why should anything happen to me? Why not simply miss out on the reward? Participants answered that Gehinnom and death are purging processes. The Rabbi agreed, and added that someone extremely evil may be beyond purging and simply cut off: karet, ceasing to exist, the greatest bad consequence. But purging or not, they are still consequences. Once there is good and bad, body and soul, and a body that can be evil, "there has to be a response to that."

Why is the soul punished?

A participant asked: if the body is the coarse part, why is it the soul that suffers in Gehinnom? The Rabbi answered that the soul should be able to overcome the body. If it lets the body take control, it is responsible. He compared it to a guardian. Halachically, if a young child wrecks your house, the parents are not liable for the damage; a parent's responsibility until bar misvah is only on a spiritual plane. But secular law would hold them liable, because they were meant to be watching. So too the soul was meant to be looking after the body.

A moment of anger

The Ramhal cites the Gemara that God's anger lasts a moment. The Rabbi explained that this moment of anger is what allows consequences, punishments and all the purging processes to exist. It is the moment Bilam was looking for in order to curse. What could he say in a split second? One answer is a single word, "kalem", destroy them. The more reasonable answer is that once you have entered that moment, you can continue in it.

He added that some use this as a proof in a halachic question. If the deadline for the Amidah is ten o'clock and I begin at 9.59 and finish at 10.04, have I fulfilled the misvah? On this reasoning, since you began in time, you may continue.

God holds back evil and guides to the end

Even after creating all this, the Ramhal continues, God sets a boundary so that evil does not take control and cause everything to decay. He shines His light back into the world. Had the illumination been complete, people would be eternal; as it is, creatures are not destroyed by the bad, but they are not eternal.

And the key point, taught many times: within this whole system there is HaKadosh Barukh Hu's overarching emanation guiding the world towards its end, the great light of the eternal world. Everything bad will eventually be banished, and a time will come when we look back and see that all the evil and imperfection was actually for the good.

§119-120: the summary

The Neshamah asks (§119): this has been a lot; please summarise. The Rabbi admitted the Ramhal "has driven this point home quite a lot."

The Sekhel's summary (§120):

- God wanted nature, and the beings within it, to be made of both good and bad, so that we would earn our reward.
- He created the world with an emanation that is good because it is from Him, and that goodness is stamped into nature.
- He then turned away the completeness of that emanation, and so all imperfection and destruction became part of nature.
- After that, He created through His emanation the creatures of the world, made of good and bad, existing but able to end at any time.

- In the end "He will make His face shine", the emanation will be perfect, the concept of decay will be banished from nature, and all beings will remain perfect and eternal.

Why both?

A participant asked about the link between two ideas: the world must contain destruction, and evil was created so we could perfect ourselves. If we perfect ourselves earlier, he suggested, we would not need to wait for 6,000 years. The Rabbi agreed: "Precisely. That's the connection between the two." Otherwise one could say evil was created only so the world would end.

Having explained at length how evil came about, the final part of Section 5 would deal with man's relationship to evil, after Pesah. Section 6 would then go into specific evil things.

Homework for Pesah

The Rabbi pointed out that the English edition has very short summaries of each section at the back (pages 653-658), "only 4-5 pages", and asked everyone to read them over the break, since the book is built "brick upon brick". Classes would resume two weeks after Pesah at 6.45 for the summer.

Summary

- Imperfection alone is not evil; God made a greater concealment so that man could truly corrupt, as if with a heavy heart.
- Once evil is possible, there must be judgment and consequences, whether purging or, at the extreme, karet.
- The soul is held responsible because it should have controlled the body.
- God's "moment of anger" allows consequences, while His light holds evil within limits and guides the world to its end.
- §120: good emanation, its partial withdrawal, creatures of mixed good and bad, and a final perfect emanation in which nothing decays.

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